VIBEPICKS · LAUNCH GUIDE

Ready, Fire, Aim.

How a machinist with little coding experience got a real website, a newsletter and a working checkout up and running with AI in one afternoon, then fine-tuned it along the way. Step by step, with the prompts I used and the mistakes I made.

Not a programmer | 29 copy-paste prompts | Real mistakes included | Honest tool costs

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vibepicks.ai

BEFORE YOU START

Read this first

I run a one-man machine shop in Pelkie, up in Michigan's Upper Peninsula. I'm a machinist, not a programmer, with only a little coding experience.

On October 15, 2026 I launched **VibePicks** (vibepicks.ai). It's a ranked guide to AI tools, sorted by what you're trying to build, plus a weekly newsletter. An AI assistant wrote the code. I told it what I wanted, checked what it made, and told it what was wrong.

This guide is how I did it, step by step, taken from the site's real history: the files, the change log and the newsletter I sent. Every date in here comes from that record.

> **What this guide is:** a build log you can follow, not a business plan. It shows how I got a real website, a newsletter and a working checkout up and running in one afternoon, then fine-tuned it as I went, with copy-paste prompts for every step and the mistakes I made.

What I built, with AI doing the coding

A real website

vibepicks.ai, on my own domain. A ranked guide to AI tools, sorted by what you're building: 16 categories and 69 tool picks today, plus a dated page of new releases.

A weekly newsletter

A signup box on the site that saves emails to my list, and issue #1 sent the next day from my own address.

A working checkout

Stripe Payment Links on the sponsor page. Tested with fake cards first, then switched to live.

The stuff around it

Automatic updates from GitHub to the live site, simple analytics, and a morning check that keeps links and prices honest.

Who this is for

Small business owners, tradespeople and anyone with an idea who wants a real website, an email list and a checkout, and doesn't want to hire a web person or learn to code. If you can write an email and follow steps, you can do this.

Who it's not for

If you already build websites for a living, you won't learn much here. And if you're looking for marketing secrets, this isn't it. This is how to build the thing.

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How to use the prompts. Every prompt in a box like the ones in this guide is meant to be copied and pasted into an AI assistant (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, or a coding tool like Cursor or Claude Code). Anything in **[PURPLE BRACKETS]** is yours to fill in. Paste them in order. If the AI's answer doesn't make sense, say so. "I don't understand, explain it simpler" is a perfectly good prompt.

A word on the AI. You'll get the most out of this with an assistant that can actually edit files on a computer (a coding agent), not just chat. Chat-only works too, but you'll be copying and pasting code yourself. Either way, you're the boss. It does the typing, you make the calls.

CHAPTER 1

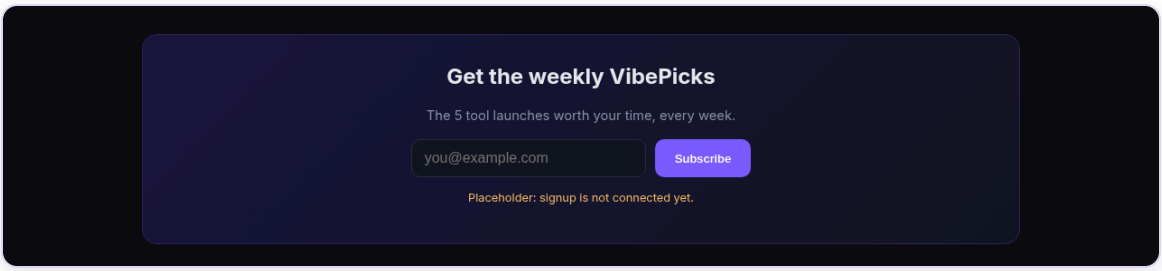
Why ready, fire, aim

In the shop, when I'm in a hurry, it's ready, fire, aim. Get the part on the machine, make a cut, measure, adjust. You learn more from one real cut than from an hour of staring at the print.

That's how I built VibePicks. I didn't plan it for months. I had it up and running the same afternoon I started, and everything since then has been fine-tuning. Launch fast, then improve.

Here's why that works better than waiting:

- **You can't fix what isn't out there.** My first version had a signup box that said "Placeholder: signup is not connected yet." Twenty-six minutes later it was connected. If I'd waited for everything to be right, I'd still be waiting.
- **Real people find real problems.** I tested my own site by asking it about a Raspberry Pi. It gave me Arduino answers. That's a problem I'd never have found by planning. We fixed it that night.
- **AI makes the fixes cheap.** When the AI is doing the typing, a fix is a sentence from you and a few minutes of its time. Being wrong costs a lot less than it used to.
- **Momentum matters.** Every day something new went live. That kept me going, and it gave me something to write about in the newsletter.



From an early preview of the homepage. The signup box wasn't hooked up yet, and it said so. That's fine. It was connected the same afternoon.

What ready, fire, aim is not

It's not sloppy. A few things I never rushed:

- **Payments.** The checkout buttons went up in Stripe's test mode first. Live links came after.
- **Facts.** Every tool, price and news item gets checked against the official source. When something can't be verified, it stays off the site.
- **Honesty.** Sponsored spots are labeled. Affiliate links are labeled. If I can't back something up, it doesn't go in.
- **Secrets.** API keys live in the hosting settings, never in the website code.

Fire fast on the stuff you can fix later. Aim carefully on the stuff that can hurt someone's wallet or trust.

CHAPTER 2

Up and running in an afternoon

The site was up and running in one afternoon. The first version went live at 3:57 PM, the signup box worked by 4:22, and the checkout was live by 5:20. Everything after that was fine-tuning. That's ready, fire, aim: launch fast, then improve.

Every time the AI saved a change to the site, it got logged with a time stamp. Here are the ones that mattered, in order, in plain English. All times are Eastern.

The afternoon · Thursday, October 15

Up and running

3:57 PM	**Version 1 goes up.** A static directory of AI tools with a page for each category, set up so Google can read it, plus an `llms.txt` file so AI search tools can read it too.
4:22 PM	**Newsletter signup works.** The box on the homepage now saves emails to Resend. Same change: a check of every tool's link and price.
4:31 PM	**Test the auto-deploy.** A tiny test change to prove that saving to GitHub makes Vercel update the live site on its own.
4:42 PM	**Sponsor page goes up,** with Stripe checkout buttons in test mode.
5:20 PM	**Checkout goes live.** Test links swapped for real Stripe Payment Links.

Fine-tuning · Thursday evening

Search box, analytics, launch post

7:52 PM	**"What are we building today?"** A box where you type what you want to make and it suggests tools. It runs in your browser with no AI calls.
8:21 PM	**Analytics turned on,** so I can see visits, signups and searches. The first try had a small bug, fixed right away (see Mistakes). Then a redeploy at 8:26 to actually turn analytics on.
Same day	**The Facebook post.** My first post in a long time, telling people what I'd built.

Fine-tuning · Friday, October 16

More categories, newsletter #1

12:08 AM	**New category: AI Images & Art,** plus more words the search box understands (art, video, voice, writing, automation).
12:17 AM	**A small AI helper** for searches the simple matcher can't figure out. It has hard limits so it can't run up a bill (more in Chapter 3).

12:22 AM	**AI Audio & Voice category.** The AI helper now says "we don't have a good pick for that" instead of guessing.
12:24 AM	**AI for Hardware & Electronics category.**
12:31 AM	**The Raspberry Pi fix.** I'd asked it about a Pi and got Arduino answers. Now it gives different picks for Arduino, Raspberry Pi, STM32 and PLCs, and adds OpenPLC.
1:15 AM	**Five more categories:** AI Video, Automations, Websites & Stores, Writing & Marketing, and CAD & Machining. That's the stuff I actually use.
2:10 AM	**Images and logo for newsletter #1** uploaded to the site so the email can show them.
8:17 AM	**First "daily ops" check.** New, verified tool releases added. Fixed a renamed tool, a couple of links and a price label that was wrong.
Friday	**Newsletter #1 goes out** from my own address.

Fine-tuning · Saturday, October 17

Affiliate links, polish

8:12 AM	**Daily ops:** eight verified releases added, plus `llms-full.txt`, a full list of every tool for AI search tools to read. Prices checked, no changes needed.
11:14 AM	**Site verification for impact.com,** the network that runs Shopify's affiliate program.
11:25 AM	**First affiliate link: Shopify,** with an "Affiliate link" label and a disclosure.
12:10 PM	**Second affiliate link: OpusClip.** Homepage top picks now show which category each one is #1 in.
12:18 PM	**"Browse categories" bar** on every page so people can hop around easier.

Fine-tuning · Sunday, October 18

Still going

8:15 AM	**Daily ops:** four verified releases, a site icon (it was missing and causing an error), smarter sitemap dates, and another price check with no changes.
2:22 PM	**Checkout cleaned up.** The sponsor page now explains how buying works step by step, and the thank-you message shows after paying.

The fine-tuning never really stops, and that's the point. Get it running first, then improve it whenever you have time.

CHAPTER 3

The tool stack and what it costs

Here's everything that runs VibePicks. Prices are from each company's own pricing page, checked October 18, 2026. They change, so check again before you sign up.

Tool	What it does for me	Free tier	When you'd pay
AI assistant	Writes all the code, drafts, fact-checks. I direct, it types.	ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini all have free plans.	Paid plans run around $20/month. Claude Pro, for example, is $20/month billed monthly. Heavy coding use can cost more.
GitHub	Stores the site's files and keeps every version.	Free: unlimited public and private repositories.	You won't need to for a site like this.
Vercel	Hosts the site. Every change saved to GitHub goes live by itself. Also runs the small signup function and analytics.	Vercel has a free tier (Hobby) for personal, non-commercial projects. It includes 100 GB of data transfer, 1M function calls and 50K analytics events a month.	**Read this:** Pro is $20/month and is the plan for commercial sites. If your site takes payments or runs sponsors, plan on Pro.
Resend	Saves newsletter signups and sends the newsletter.	Free: up to 1,000 marketing contacts, plus 3,000 transactional emails a month (100 a day).	Pro Marketing starts at $40/month for 5,000 contacts.
Stripe	Takes card payments through Payment Links on my sponsor page.	No setup or monthly fee. Payment Links cost nothing extra.	2.9% + 30¢ per successful US card payment. On a $49 payment, that's about $1.72.
Domain	The address people type.	None.	A .com is $11.25/year at Vercel. A .ai is $160 for the 2-year minimum there. Prices vary by registrar.
Facebook	Where I announced it.	Free.	I didn't run ads.

What it actually takes to start

The bare minimum

A .com domain (about $11 a year) and free tiers of everything else. If your AI's free plan holds up, that's it.

What I'd budget

A domain, one paid AI plan around $20/month, and Vercel Pro at $20/month once the site is commercial (taking payments or running sponsors). Stripe only charges a fee when a payment goes through.

> **Why a static site?** A static site is just files: pages, pictures, a stylesheet. No database, no login system, nothing to hack or patch. VibePicks keeps all its content (16 categories, 69 tools and the releases list as of today) in one data file. A small script turns that file into all the pages, the sitemap and the files AI search tools read. To add a tool, the AI edits one file and runs the script.

The one part that could cost money by surprise

The "smart" search helper calls an AI model through Vercel's AI Gateway, and that's billed by use. So we put hard limits on it: 10 searches an hour per visitor, 500 a day for the whole site, and repeat questions are answered from memory instead of asking the AI again. It also only kicks in when the free, in-browser matcher can't figure out a search. If you add anything that calls an AI on your site, ask for limits like these on day one.

How the pieces connect

You tell the AI what you want. It edits the files and saves them to **GitHub**. **Vercel** sees the change and puts the new version live on your domain in about a minute. When someone types their email, a tiny function on Vercel hands it to **Resend**, using a secret key stored in Vercel's settings. When someone clicks Buy, **Stripe** takes the card and sends them back to a thank-you message. That's the whole machine.

CHAPTER 4

1 Pick a niche

Pick something you already know better than most people. Don't pick what's hot. Pick what you'd talk about for free.

What I did

I was frustrated trying to figure out which AI tool to use for what. Every week there were ten new ones and everybody said theirs was best. I run a shop. I don't have time to chase all that. So the niche picked itself: sort AI tools by what you're actually trying to build, and keep the list short.

Later I added categories from my own world, like CAD & Machining and AI for Hardware & Electronics, because that's the stuff I use. That's an edge nobody can copy: your own experience.

How to pick yours

- **Start from a problem you've had.** If it bugged you, it bugs other people.
- **Make it a list or a guide, not an app.** A ranked list, a how-to, a directory. These are simple static sites, and they're easy to keep up.
- **Keep it narrow.** "AI tools sorted by job" beats "everything about AI."

> Write one sentence before you do anything else: **"[Site] helps [who] [do what]."** Mine: VibePicks helps regular builders find the right AI tool for what they're making. If you can't write that sentence, you're not ready to build yet.

The prompts

1 Find a niche you already know

Start here. Fill in the brackets.

```
I run [YOUR BUSINESS OR JOB] and I'm not a programmer. I want to build a simple website plus a
weekly email newsletter for people like [WHO YOU WANT TO HELP].
Give me 10 niche ideas where I already know more than the average person. For each one tell me:
1. Who it's for, in one sentence
2. What the website would list, rank or explain
3. How it could make money later (sponsors, affiliate links, selling something)
4. How crowded it already is, honestly
Keep it plain. No hype.
```

2 Poke holes in my idea

Once you have a favorite.

```
Here's my idea: [YOUR IDEA IN 2-3 SENTENCES].
Poke holes in it. Who else already does this? Why would someone pick mine? What would make it fail in the first 90 days?
Then tell me the smallest version I could put online this week that's still useful to a real person.
```

3 Name ideas

Before you buy a domain.

```
Give me 20 short, easy-to-spell names for a site about [YOUR NICHE]. Two syllables is ideal.
Avoid names that are hard to say out loud or easy to misspell. Don't tell me whether the domains are available. I'll check that myself on a domain site.
```

CHAPTER 5

2 Get a domain

A domain is your address on the internet. It's the one thing in this guide you'll pay for no matter what.

What I did

I went with **vibepicks.ai**. The .ai ending fits a site about AI tools, but it's pricey. At Vercel today a .ai domain is $160 for the two-year minimum. A .com is $11.25 a year there.

How to do yours

- **Get a .com if you can.** It's cheap and people trust it. Only pay up for a fancy ending if it really fits.
- **Buy it where you'll host, if you can.** Buying it right in Vercel means fewer settings to get right. Any registrar works, you'll just have a couple more DNS steps.
- **Say it out loud.** If you have to spell it for someone on the phone, pick another one.
- **Grab the matching email name too.** You'll want to send your newsletter from something like news@yourdomain.com.

> **Watch out for renewals.** Some places sell the first year cheap and charge a lot more after. Look at the renewal price, not just the sale price.

The prompts

4 Domains and DNS in plain English

Before you buy, or right after.

```
Explain like I've never done this: what a domain is, what DNS is, and what I'll need to do to
point [YOURDOMAIN.COM] at a website hosted on Vercel.
Go step by step. Tell me what each screen will roughly look like and what to click. Don't assume I
know any of the terms.
```

CHAPTER 6

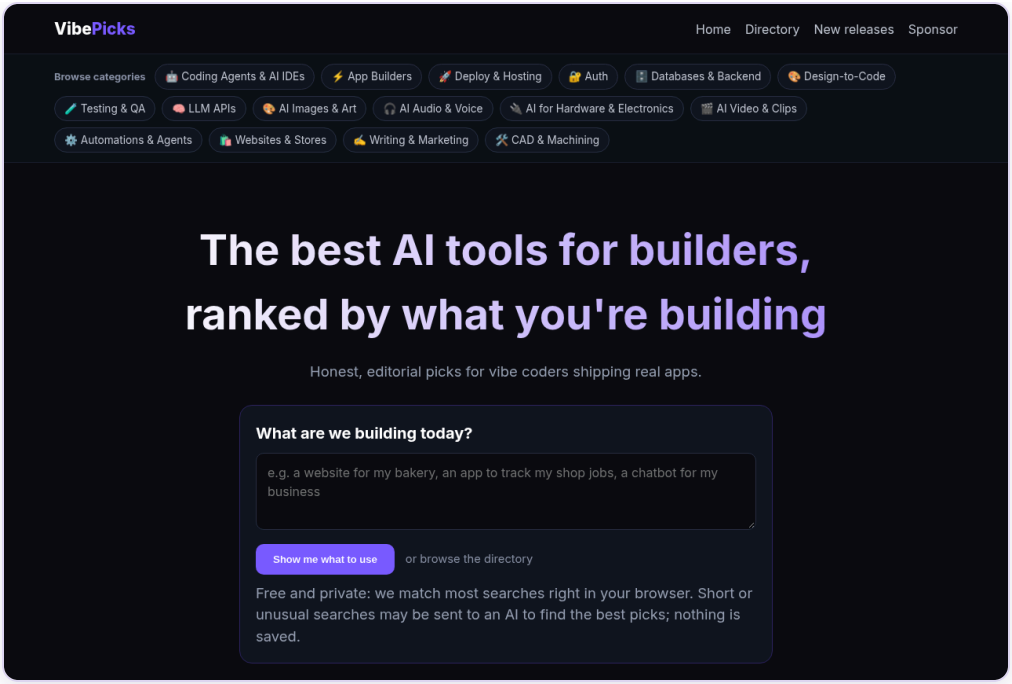
3 Have AI build a static site

This is the part people think is hard. It isn't, as long as you keep it simple and tell the AI exactly what you want.

What I did

The first version of VibePicks went up at 3:57 PM on day 1. It was a static site: plain pages, a stylesheet and a bit of JavaScript. No database. Every tool lives in one data file, and a small script builds all the category pages, the sitemap for Google, and a file called `llms.txt` that helps AI search tools understand the site.

I didn't write any of it. I said what I wanted, looked at what it made, and said what was wrong. Over and over.



The VibePicks homepage today: category bar, headline, and the "What are we building today?" box.

Rules that kept it simple

- **Static first.** No logins, no database. Fewer things to break.
- **One data file for content.** Adding a tool means editing one file, not ten pages.
- **Ask for a file list.** Make the AI tell you every file it made and what it does. You don't have to understand the code, but you should know what's there.
- **Look at it yourself.** On your computer and your phone. Click everything.

The prompts

5 The first build (the big one)

Your very first message to the AI that will write the code.

```
You're building my website. I'm not a programmer. You write all the code and I'll tell you what I want.
Build a simple static website (plain HTML, CSS and a little JavaScript, no frameworks, no database) for [SITE NAME], which [WHAT IT DOES IN ONE SENTENCE].
- Keep all the content in one data file (like a JSON file) so I can change text and add items without touching the code.
- Pages: a home page, one page per [CATEGORY / SERVICE / TOPIC], and a sponsor page that's just a placeholder for now.
- Dark theme with [YOUR COLOR] as the accent. Must look good on a phone.
- Give every page a real title and description for Google, and make a sitemap.xml and robots.txt.
When you're done, list every file you made and what it does in one line each.
```

6 Make it sound like me

After the first version is up on your screen.

```
Go through every page and rewrite anything that sounds like marketing. Short sentences. Plain
words. Write it the way a [YOUR TRADE] owner would explain it to a customer at the counter.
Here are a few lines of how I actually talk: [PASTE 3-4 SENTENCES YOU WROTE].
Don't change any links, prices or facts. Show me the before and after for anything you change.
```

7 Check it on a phone

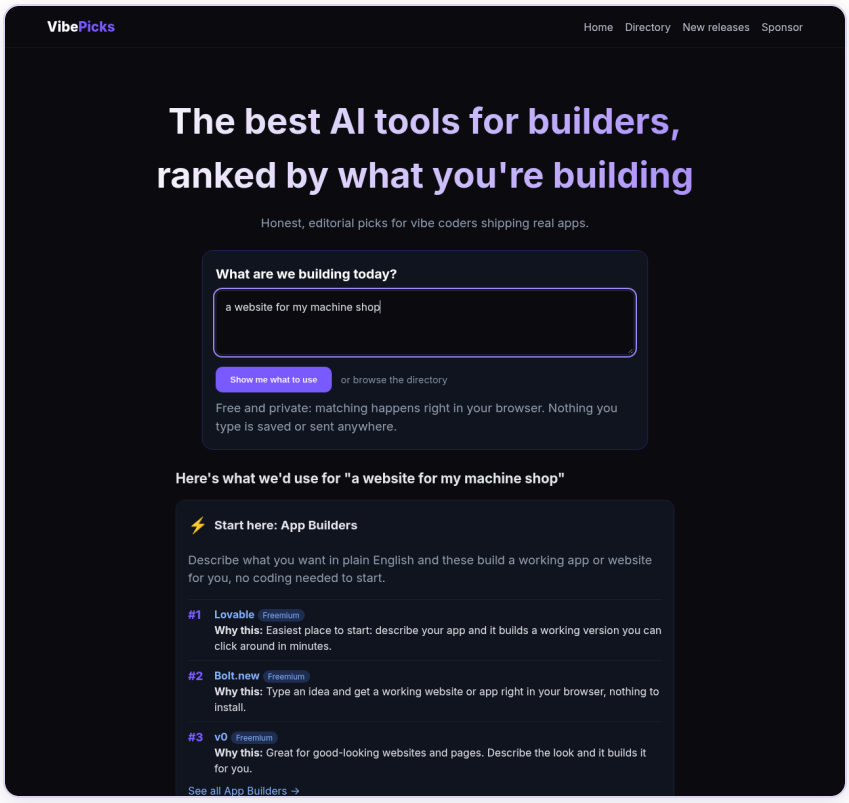
Before you show anyone.

```
Pretend you're on a small phone screen. Go through every page and tell me anything that's cut off,
too small to tap, overlapping or hard to read. Then fix it and tell me what you changed in plain
English.
```

8 Add a helper that answers "what should I use?"

Optional. This is what our recommender does.

```
Add a box on the home page that says "[YOUR QUESTION, e.g. What are we building today?]". When
someone types what they want, match it to the right [CATEGORIES] from my data file and show the
top picks with a one-line reason each.
Do the matching right in the browser with keywords and synonyms. No AI calls and nothing saved.
Tell me which words map to which category so I can add more.
```



The recommender on day 1. It matched "a website for my machine shop" to app builders and hosting, right in the browser.

CHAPTER 7

4 Put it online with GitHub and Vercel

GitHub holds your files. Vercel turns them into a live website. Once they're connected, you never "upload" anything again.

What I did

The site's files live in a GitHub repository. Vercel watches it. Any time the AI saves a change to GitHub, Vercel builds the new version and puts it live on vibepicks.ai, usually in about a minute.

At 4:31 PM on day 1 we made a tiny test change, just to prove the connection worked. Do the same. It's a lot better to find out it's broken when nothing's riding on it.

How to do yours

1. Make free accounts at GitHub and Vercel. Sign in to Vercel with your GitHub account so they're linked from the start.
2. Have the AI walk you through putting your site in a **private** GitHub repository.
3. In Vercel, import that repository. For a plain static site there's nothing to configure.
4. Add your domain in Vercel and follow its DNS instructions.
5. Make one small test change and check that it shows up on the live site.

Keep secrets out of GitHub. API keys and passwords go in Vercel's **Environment Variables** settings, never in your files. Tell your AI this up front. If a key ever lands in your code by accident, turn that key off in the service that issued it and make a new one.

If something breaks, Vercel keeps every past version. You can roll back to the last good one from the dashboard with a click. That's what makes ready, fire, aim safe.

The prompts

9 Put it on GitHub, one step at a time

When the site works on your computer.

```
Walk me through putting this website into a GitHub repository. I've never used git.
Tell me exactly what to click or type, one step at a time, and wait for me to say "done" before
you give me the next step. Make the repository private. Make sure no passwords or API keys end up
in it.
```

10 Connect Vercel and your domain

Right after GitHub.

```
Walk me through connecting my GitHub repository to Vercel so the site deploys automatically every
time a change is saved to GitHub. Then walk me through adding my domain [YOURDOMAIN.COM] and the
DNS records I need at [WHERE YOU BOUGHT THE DOMAIN].
One step at a time. Wait for me to say "done" between steps.
```

11 Prove the auto-deploy works

Do this once, on purpose.

```
Make one small, harmless change to the site (like a word in the footer), save it to GitHub, and
tell me where in Vercel to watch it deploy. Then tell me how to check that the live site changed,
and how to undo it if something breaks.
```

CHAPTER 8

5 Add an email signup with Resend

The email list is the most valuable thing you'll build. Facebook can bury your posts. Your list is yours.

What I did

Twenty-six minutes after version 1 went up, the signup box worked. Before that it said, in plain words, "Placeholder: signup is not connected yet."

Here's how it works, in plain English. When someone types their email and hits Subscribe, the page sends it to a tiny function on Vercel. That function checks the email looks real, then saves it as a contact in my newsletter list in Resend. It never sends an email by itself. The Resend key it uses is stored in Vercel's settings, so it never shows up in the website code.

There's also a hidden field that people can't see but spam bots fill in. If it's filled in, the function quietly pretends it worked and throws the signup away.

How to do yours

1. Make a free Resend account. Free covers up to 1,000 newsletter contacts.
2. Verify your domain in Resend (a few DNS records) so your emails don't land in spam.
3. Make a list (Resend calls it a segment) for your newsletter.
4. Create an API key in Resend and paste it into Vercel's Environment Variables yourself. Don't paste it into the chat.
5. Have the AI build the signup box and function. Then test it like a customer.

The prompts

12 Add the signup box

When the site is live on your domain.

```
Add a newsletter signup box to my home page. Save each email as a contact in Resend, in a segment
called "[NEWSLETTER NAME]".
- Do it with a small serverless function on Vercel at /api/subscribe so my Resend API key stays in
Vercel's environment variables and never shows up in the website code.
- Add a hidden "honeypot" field to stop bots.
- Show a friendly thank-you message, and a plain error message if something goes wrong.
- Don't send any email yet. Just save the contact.
Then tell me exactly where to paste my API key in Vercel. I'll do that part myself.
```

13 Verify your domain for email

So your newsletter doesn't land in spam.

```
Walk me through verifying [YOURDOMAIN.COM] in Resend so I can send from an address like
news@[YOURDOMAIN.COM]. Tell me which DNS records to add, where to add them, and how long it
usually takes to show as verified. One step at a time.
```

14 Test the signup like a customer

Before you launch.

```
Give me a short test checklist for my signup box: a real email, the same email twice, a bad email
like "bob@", on my phone, and with the honeypot field filled in. For each one, tell me what I
should see and where to check in Resend that it worked (or didn't).
```

CHAPTER 9

6 Write newsletter #1

Your first issue doesn't have to be long. It has to be useful and it has to sound like you.

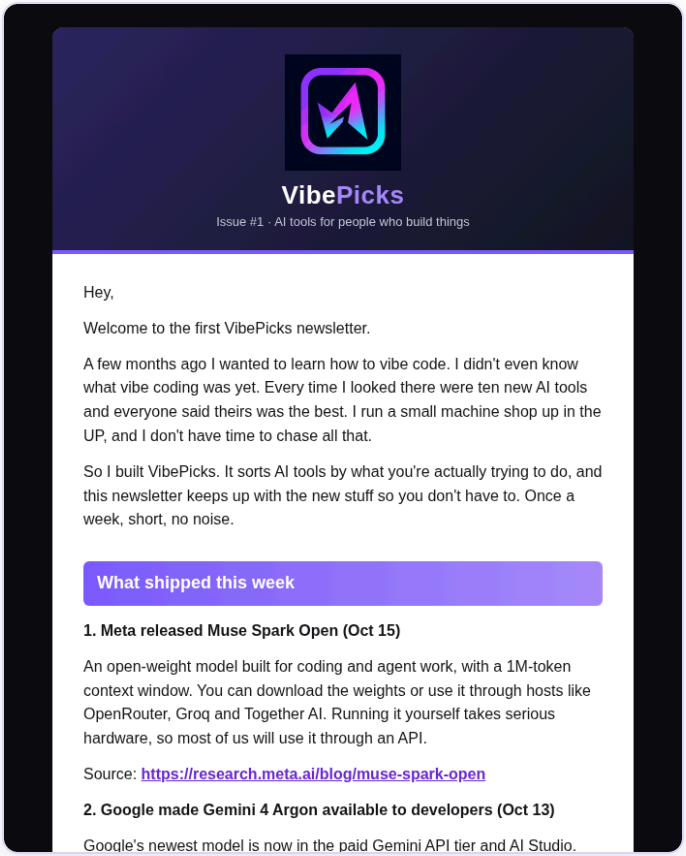
What I did

Issue #1 went out on day 2. Here's how it was laid out:

- **A short hello.** Who I am, why I built it. "I run a small machine shop up in the UP, and I don't have time to chase all that."
- **What shipped this week.** Five AI tool releases, each with a date and a link to the official source.
- **Crazy tech this week.** Two fun stories with photos.
- **Try this prompt.** One prompt anybody can use, for reading a confusing bill.
- **Quick picks.** Three links into the site.
- **Sponsor.** One line.

- **Sign-off.** "If something's missing or you'd rank it different, just hit reply. I read every one."

The subject line was plain: *What actually shipped this week in AI building tools.*



The top of VibePicks #1: logo, a short hello, then "What shipped this week."

Decide on tracking first. Open and click tracking was off on my sending domain, so I don't have an open rate for issue #1. It's a setting in Resend, on every plan. Pick on purpose before you send.

Always send a test to yourself first. Check it on your phone. Click every link. Then send to the list.

The prompts

15 Write newsletter #1

After the site is live and a few people have signed up.

```
Help me write the first issue of my weekly newsletter, [NAME]. It's for [WHO]. Keep it short.
Sections:
1. A short hello: who I am and why I started this (I'll give you the facts: [YOUR STORY IN 3 LINES])
2. [3-5] things that happened this week in [MY NICHE], each with a date and a link to the official source
3. One fun or surprising thing
4. One useful tip they can try today
5. Quick links to the best pages on my site
6. One line about sponsoring, and a sign-off asking them to hit reply
Use only facts you can link to an official source. If you're not sure, leave it out and tell me.
```

16 Fact-check before you send

Every issue. No exceptions.

```
Check every claim, date, number and link in this newsletter against the original source. Give me a list: what's verified (with the link), what's wrong, and what you couldn't verify. Don't make up a source. If a link is dead or goes to the wrong page, say so.
[PASTE YOUR NEWSLETTER]
```

17 Turn it into an email that looks right

When the words are final.

```
Turn this newsletter into a simple HTML email that looks right in Gmail, Outlook and on a phone.
My logo on top, one column, [YOUR COLOR] headings, big readable text.
Include an unsubscribe link using Resend's unsubscribe placeholder. Also give me a plain-text version. Send me a test first. Don't send it to the list.
```

18 Subject lines without clickbait

Last step before sending.

```
Give me 5 subject lines for this issue. Plain, honest, under 50 characters, no ALL CAPS, no "you won't believe". Tell me which one you'd pick and why in one sentence.
```

CHAPTER 10

7 Tell people on Facebook

You don't need a following. You need the people who already know you.

What I did

On launch day I made my first Facebook post in a long time. No ads, no tricks. Just me saying what I built and why.

Why a plain post works

- **People knew me.** Friends, customers, people from around here. A guy from the shop building an AI website is a story.
- **It wasn't an ad.** It was a person saying "I made this."
- **There was one clear thing to do:** check it out and sign up.

How to do yours

- Write it in your own words first, even if it's rough. Then have the AI tighten it, not rewrite it.
- Say who you are, why you built it, what it does, and what you want them to do.
- Put the link at the end. Click it yourself before you post.
- Answer every comment that day. That's half the reach.

The prompts

19 Write the launch post

Launch day.

```
Help me write a Facebook post announcing [SITE NAME]. I haven't posted in a long time, so it
should feel like me, not an ad.
Say who I am, why I built it, what it does in one sentence, and ask people to check it out and
sign up for the newsletter. Put the link at the end.
Under 150 words. No hashtags, no hype, one emoji at most.
Here's how I write: [PASTE A FEW SENTENCES YOU WROTE].
```

20 Reply to comments

The day of the post and the day after.

```
People are commenting on my launch post. Here are the comments: [PASTE THEM].
Write a short, friendly reply for each one in my voice. If someone asks a question, answer it
plainly. If someone points out a problem, thank them and tell them I'll fix it. Don't be salesy.
```

CHAPTER 11

8 A working checkout with Stripe

You don't need a store or a programmer. Stripe Payment Links give you a real, working checkout without any code.

What I did

My checkout lives on the VibePicks sponsor page. It went up at 4:42 PM on day 1 with Stripe's test-mode links. At 5:20 PM we swapped in live links. Here's what's on it today:

Option	Price	What they get
Featured Listing	$49 for 30 days	A labeled Sponsored spot on the site
Newsletter Sponsor	$75/issue	One sponsored block in a newsletter issue, labeled Sponsored
Category Top Spot	$249/month	A pinned slot above the rankings on one category page, labeled Sponsored

Each Buy button is just a Stripe Payment Link. Stripe hosts the actual card form, so card numbers never touch my site. The checkout asks for an email and a couple of details, and after someone pays, Stripe sends them back to the page with a thank-you message. The page also spells out the rules: sponsored spots are always labeled, affiliate links are labeled, and paying never changes rankings.

If you reach out to sponsors

Only contact companies whose tools are already on your site. Find a real public address and know where it came from. Say plainly that you're new, and never put a number in an email that you can't back up. The last two prompts below help with that.

> **Test mode first, always.** Stripe gives you a sandbox with fake cards. Buy your own product there before you go live. That's how you know the checkout really works. And never paste your Stripe secret keys into a chat. Payment Links don't need any code keys at all.

The prompts

21 Build a sponsor page

When you have something people could pay for.

```
Replace my placeholder sponsor page with a real one. Three options:
- [OPTION 1] - $[PRICE] - [WHAT THEY GET]
- [OPTION 2] - $[PRICE] - [WHAT THEY GET]
- [OPTION 3] - $[PRICE] - [WHAT THEY GET]
Each "Buy" button links to a Stripe Payment Link. Use placeholder links for now and I'll paste the real ones.
Add an honest note that we're new and the audience is small. Add our rules: every sponsored spot is labeled "Sponsored", affiliate links are labeled, and money never changes the rankings.
Show a thank-you message when the page is opened with ?thanks=1 at the end of the address.
```

22 Stripe Payment Links: test first, then live

Before you paste any links.

```
Walk me through creating Stripe Payment Links for my three sponsor options. Do it in test mode (sandbox) first so I can make a fake purchase with a test card.
Set each link to send buyers back to [YOURDOMAIN.COM]/sponsor/?thanks=1 after they pay. When the test works, walk me through making the same links in live mode and swapping them onto the page.
```

23 Find the right person to pitch

Before you write a pitch.

```
Find the public contact address for sponsorships, partnerships or marketing at [COMPANY]. Tell me exactly which page you found it on (give me the link). If there's no partnerships address, say so and give me the best public one instead. Don't guess an address.
```

24 Write an honest sponsor pitch

One per company.

```
Write a short sponsor pitch email to [COMPANY]. Their tool [TOOL] is ranked #[RANK] on my [CATEGORY] page: [LINK].
Use only these real numbers: [YOUR NUMBERS]. Don't invent an open rate, click rate or anything else. Say plainly that we're new.
Offer: [YOUR OFFER]. Under 150 words. Sign it [YOUR NAME], [SITE].
```

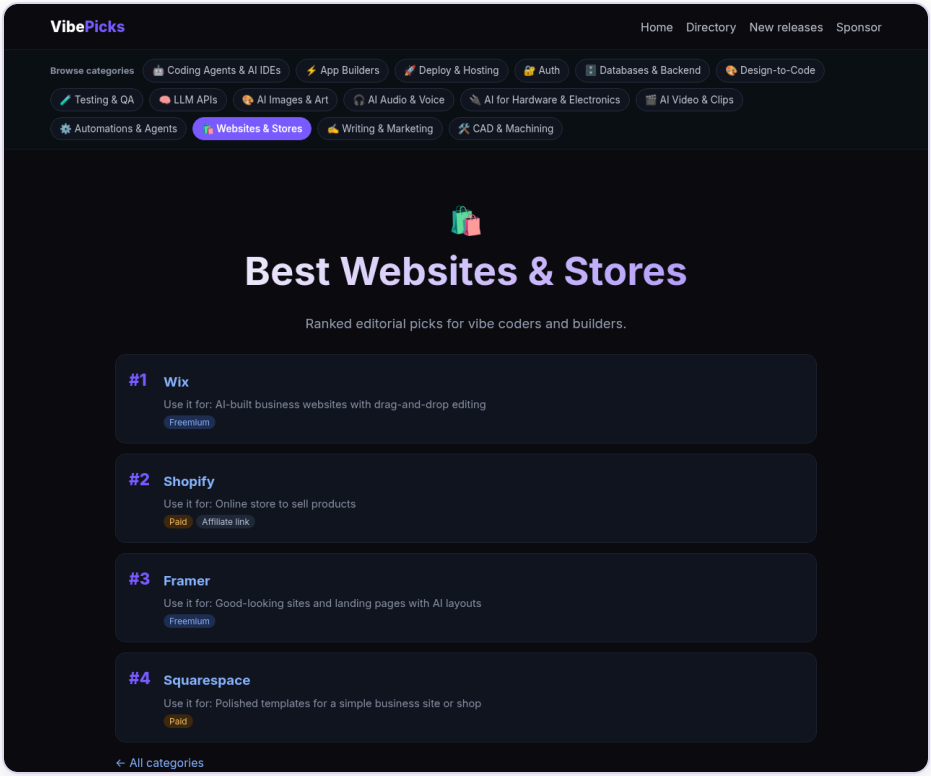
CHAPTER 12

9 Affiliate links, honestly

An affiliate link is a tracked link a company gives you for their product. It's fine to use them. It's not fine to hide them.

What I did

On day 3 I joined two affiliate programs: **Shopify** (through the impact.com network, which needed a small verification tag on the site) and **OpusClip**. Both tools were already ranked on VibePicks before I applied. Shopify is #2 on Websites & Stores. That's where it was before the affiliate deal and that's where it stayed.



Shopify keeps its #2 spot, with a small "Affiliate link" tag right next to it.

The rules I follow

- **Only tools I'd recommend anyway.** If it isn't already on the list, an affiliate program won't put it there.
- **Label it where it is.** An "Affiliate link" tag next to every affiliate link, everywhere it shows up.
- **Mark it in the code.** Affiliate links get `rel="sponsored"`, which tells search engines it's a paid link.
- **Say it in plain words.** The sponsor page says which links are affiliate links, that they cost the reader nothing extra, and that affiliate deals never change rankings.

- **Click every link yourself.** Tracking links bounce through another address. Make sure they land where you meant.

> **Before you apply,** check that the tool is already on your list on its own merits, read the program's current terms on its own site, and paste (don't type) your email into the application.

The prompts

25 Find affiliate programs for tools you'd recommend anyway

Only for tools already on your site.

```
These tools are already on my site because I'd recommend them anyway: [LIST]. For each one, find
out if it has an affiliate program. Give me the signup page, the commission, the payout minimum,
how you get paid and how long approval takes, with the link to the page you got it from.
Mark anything you couldn't confirm. Don't recommend adding tools just because they pay.
```

26 Add an affiliate link the honest way

After you're approved.

```
Add my affiliate link for [TOOL]: [YOUR LINK].
- Keep [TOOL]'s ranking exactly where it is.
- Mark the link rel="sponsored".
- Show a small "Affiliate link" tag next to it everywhere it appears.
- Add a disclosure line on my sponsor page: some links are affiliate links, I may earn a
commission at no extra cost to you, and affiliate deals never change rankings.
Then list every page where the link now appears so I can click each one myself.
```

CHAPTER 13

10 Keep it running

Launching is one day. Keeping it useful is every day after. The good news: the AI does most of it.

What I do now

- **Morning check-up.** Every morning since day 2 there's a "daily ops" pass: add new releases that can be verified from an official source, check tool links and prices, fix anything that's changed. Day 2 caught a renamed tool and a wrong price label. Days 3 and 4 found nothing to change. That's fine. Checking is the job.
- **Fix what people find.** When something acts wrong, I describe what I did, what happened and what I expected. The AI finds it and fixes it.

- **Simple analytics.** Vercel Web Analytics shows visits, plus two events we added: signups and searches.
- **Make it easy to get around.** On day 3 we added a "Browse categories" bar on every page, because hopping between categories was a pain.
- **Help AI search tools find you.** We added `llms.txt` and a full `llms-full.txt` so AI chatbots can read the whole list, and dates on the releases page so they can cite them.

The prompts

27 Fix what's broken (the ready-fire-aim loop)

Any time something doesn't act right.

```
Here's what I did: [WHAT YOU TYPED OR CLICKED].
Here's what happened: [WHAT YOU SAW].
Here's what I expected: [WHAT SHOULD HAVE HAPPENED].
Find out why, fix it, and tell me in plain English what was wrong. Then tell me how to check that
it's fixed on the live site.
```

28 Morning check-up

Once a day, or once a week.

```
Check the pricing and links for these items on my site against their official pages: [LIST OR
"everything in the data file"].
List only what changed, with the official link. Don't change anything you can't verify. Then check
the site for broken links and errors and tell me what you found.
```

29 Add simple analytics

When you want to know what's working.

```
Add Vercel Web Analytics to my site and track two events: someone signs up for the newsletter, and
someone [OTHER ACTION, e.g. uses the search box]. Tell me in plain English what it collects, where
I'll see the numbers, and whether I need to redeploy to turn it on.
```

CHAPTER 14

Mistakes we made, and the fixes

Ready, fire, aim means you'll miss sometimes. Here's where we did, so you don't have to.

1. **I typo'd my own email domain on an application**

   On one of the sign-up applications I typed my email domain wrong. That's how you miss the approval email and never know why.

   Fix: Never type your business email into a form. Copy and paste it from one place every time, and read the whole form back before you hit submit.

2. **Tracking links can lose your page**

   Affiliate and email tracking links bounce people through another address before they land. Sometimes they don't land where you meant, like a homepage instead of the exact page you linked.

   Fix: After adding any tracking link, click it yourself, on your phone too, and make sure it ends up on the right page. Do it again after any change.

3. **Affiliate links have to be labeled**

   It's not enough to have a disclosure buried somewhere. If a link is an affiliate link, people should know it right there, next to the link.

   Fix: Every affiliate link on VibePicks has an "Affiliate link" tag next to it, is marked as sponsored in the code, and the sponsor page says plainly that affiliate deals never change rankings.

4. **Raspberry Pi got Arduino answers**

   I tested my own site with a Raspberry Pi question and it recommended Arduino tools. Wrong board, wrong tools.

   Fix: We made the picks board-aware. Arduino, Pi, STM32 and PLCs each get their own picks now. Test your own site like a customer would, with real questions from your own work.

5. **The analytics code had a bug**

   The first try at adding analytics had a small code error in the script that makes the pages. And once that was fixed, we still had to redeploy the site before analytics actually turned on.

   Fix: It was fixed 5 seconds later and redeployed 5 minutes after that. The lesson: after any change, look at the live site, not just the AI's word that it worked.

6. **No open rate for newsletter #1**

   Open and click tracking was turned off on our sending domain, so I don't know how many people opened issue #1. That's a number I simply don't have.

   Fix: Decide before your first send whether you want tracking. It's a setting in Resend, and it's on every plan. Either way, never make up a number to fill the gap.

7 Tool info goes stale fast

In the first daily check we found a tool that had been renamed (Windsurf is now Devin Desktop) and one marked "Freemium" whose free tier is really just a 7-day trial.

Fix: A morning check of links and prices against official pages. Anything that can't be verified doesn't change.

8 A missing site icon

No little icon in the browser tab, and it caused an error behind the scenes on every visit. Small, but it looks unfinished.

Fix: Added on day 4. Put it on your day-1 list instead.

9 Not every company has a partnerships email

When I went looking for the right person to email at a few of the companies on my site, some only listed a general support address, and one partnerships address only showed up on a social profile, not their own site.

Fix: Have the AI find the public address and tell you where it found it. Use the best public one and ask them to pass it along. Don't guess.

10 Free plans have fine print

Vercel has a free tier, but it's for personal, non-commercial projects. Commercial sites belong on Pro at $20/month. That's easy to miss when you're excited.

Fix: Read the plan terms for every tool you use, and pick the plan that fits what your site actually does.

CHAPTER 15

What you end up with

If you follow the steps, here's what you'll have at the end. It's what I have, and I'm still not a programmer.

What	What it does
A website on your own domain	Plain, fast pages built from one data file. Looks right on a phone. Google and AI search tools can read it.
Automatic updates	Save a change to GitHub and Vercel puts it live in about a minute. Every old version is kept, so you can roll back with a click.
An email signup	Saves each new subscriber to your Resend list. Your key stays hidden in Vercel's settings. Bots get filtered out.
A weekly newsletter	Sent from your own address, fact-checked, with a working unsubscribe link.
A working checkout	Stripe Payment Links, tested with fake cards first, with a thank-you message after paying. No code keys needed.
Honest labels	Sponsored spots and affiliate links are marked right where they show up.
A routine	A morning check of links and prices, simple analytics, and a fix loop for when something acts up.

What it actually took

- **Very little coding.** The AI wrote the code. I described what I wanted, looked at what it made, and said what was wrong.
- **One afternoon to get it running.** The site, the signup and the checkout were live the first afternoon. The first newsletter went out the next day. Everything since has been fine-tuning.
- **Patience with mistakes.** Chapter 14 has ten of them. None were a big deal because I caught them early and fixed them.

What I'd do differently

- Add the site icon on day 1, not day 4.
- Decide on email open tracking before the first send.
- Read every plan's terms before signing up, not after.
- Paste my email into forms instead of typing it.

> **The real win** is that a guy who runs a lathe and a mill for a living now has a website, a weekly newsletter and a working checkout, up and running in an afternoon with AI doing the coding. That part, you can copy.

CHAPTER 16

The launch checklist

Same steps as the guide, in order. There's also a separate one-page version you can print.

Plan

- [ ] Pick a niche you already know
- [ ] Write one sentence: who it's for and what it does
- [ ] Pick a short name you can say out loud
- [ ] Buy the domain

Build

- [ ] First build prompt: static site, one data file
- [ ] Rewrite it in your own voice
- [ ] Check every page on your phone
- [ ] Add a site icon

Put it online

- [ ] Files in a private GitHub repo
- [ ] Connected to Vercel, deploying on its own
- [ ] Domain pointed at Vercel, https working
- [ ] Made one test change and watched it go live

Email

- [ ] Signup box saves to Resend
- [ ] API key only in Vercel settings, not in code
- [ ] Sending domain verified in Resend
- [ ] Decided on open/click tracking
- [ ] Tested signup: good, bad, duplicate, phone

Launch

- [ ] Launch post written in your voice
- [ ] Clicked the link in the post yourself
- [ ] Posted, and answered every comment

Newsletter #1

- [ ] Drafted with real, linked sources
- [ ] Fact-checked every claim and link
- [ ] Test email sent to yourself first
- [ ] Unsubscribe link works
- [ ] Sent, and wrote down the delivery numbers

Checkout

- [ ] Checkout page with clear options and prices
- [ ] Stripe Payment Links tested in test mode
- [ ] Live links swapped in, thank-you message works
- [ ] No Stripe secret keys pasted into any chat

Affiliates

- [ ] Only for tools you'd recommend anyway
- [ ] Email pasted, not typed, on every application
- [ ] Every affiliate link labeled on the page
- [ ] Disclosure on the sponsor/about page
- [ ] Clicked every tracking link, landed right

Keep going

- [ ] Hosting plan fits commercial use (Vercel Pro, $20/mo)
- [ ] Weekly newsletter on the calendar
- [ ] Regular check of links and prices

If a machinist from Pelkie can do it, so can you.

I didn't need a computer science degree for any of this. It took a lot of trial and error and being OK with it not being perfect on day one.

Pick something you know. Get it online this week. Tell people about it honestly. Fix it as you go.

Ready, fire, aim.

Chris

Prices checked October 18, 2026 and subject to change. Tool names are trademarks of their owners. VibePicks has affiliate relationships with Shopify and OpusClip, mentioned in this guide.